

Market Positioning Note – International Financial Centers

Competitive Benchmarking: GCC & Asia-Pacific Peer Analysis

Date: 1 June 2026

Classification: Confidential

Prepared by: Strategy & Research Unit

Version: 2.1

1. Purpose

This note provides the CSO with a structured view of how our center compares to its primary competitors across five strategic dimensions: regulatory environment, talent availability, digital infrastructure, cost of doing business, and brand reputation among institutional investors.

2. Peer Benchmarking Matrix

Dimension	Our Center	DIFC (Dubai)	ADGM (Abu Dhabi)	MAS (Singapore)	QFC (Qatar)
Regulatory Speed	★★★★■	★★★★★	★★★██	★★★★■	★★★██
Digital Asset Framework	★★★★■	★★★★★	★★★██	★★★★■	★★███
Talent Pool	★★★██	★★★★■	★★★██	★★★★★	★★███
Cost Competitiveness	★★★★★	★★★██	★★★★■	★★★██	★★★★■
Investor Brand	★★★██	★★★★★	★★★★■	★★★★★	★★★██

3. Key Competitive Observations

DIFC continues to lead on brand recognition and regulatory speed, having processed 1,200+ new registrations in Q1 2026. Their Virtual Assets Regulatory Authority (VARA) has become the benchmark digital asset regulator in the region. However, their cost structure is significantly higher, creating an opening for us on cost-sensitive mid-market firms.

Singapore's MAS remains the gold standard for talent and institutional credibility globally, but its tighter approach to crypto licensing since 2025 has created discontent among digital asset businesses, several of whom are actively evaluating alternatives.

ADGM has made aggressive moves in sustainable finance, launching the Abu Dhabi Sustainable Finance Declaration with 100+ signatories. This is a gap in our current offering that should be addressed.

4. Strategic Recommendations

- Accelerate digital asset licensing to close the gap with DIFC — target 90-day processing SLA.
- Develop a 'Cost Leadership' narrative for mid-market asset managers and fintechs.
- Launch an ESG/Sustainable Finance initiative to compete with ADGM's positioning.
- Invest in talent attraction through visa facilitation and housing allowance programs.